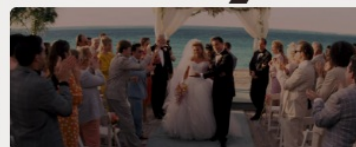
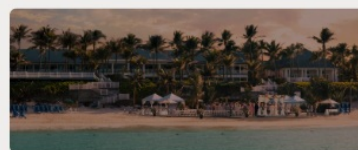
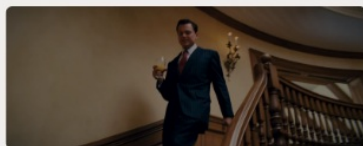
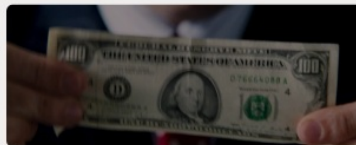


The Wolf of Wall Street.

Ambition, wealth and the illusion of control.
A colour analysis of Martin Scorsese's The Wolf of Wall Street.



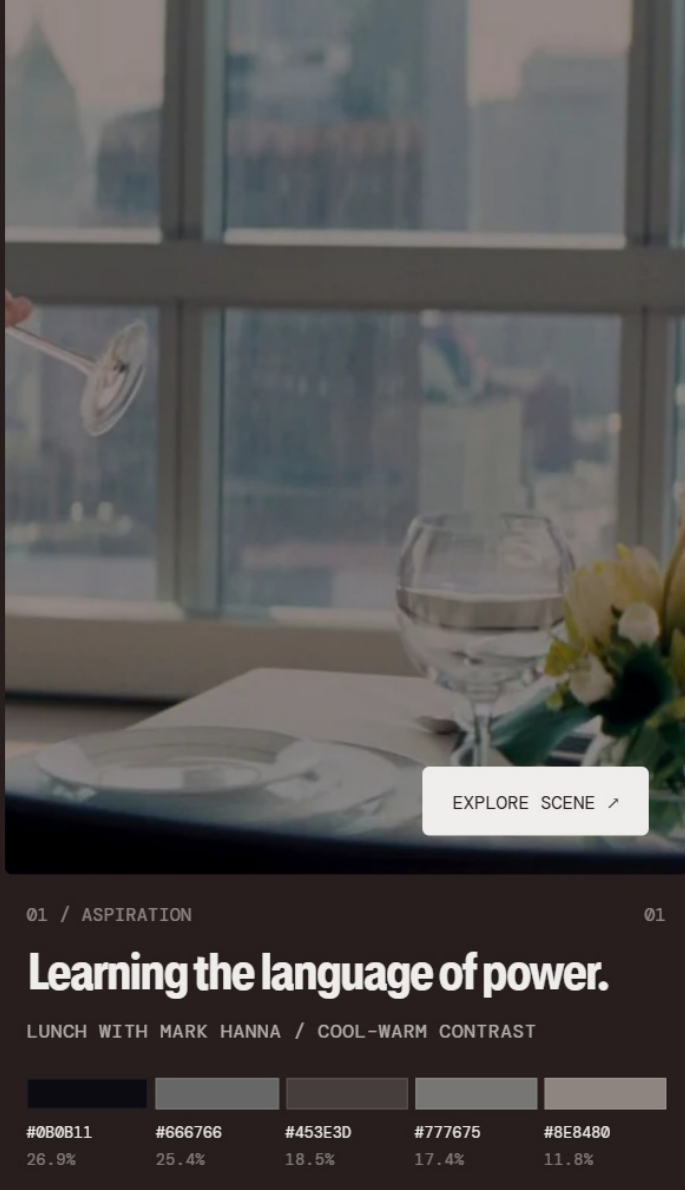
The story of Jordan Belfort. From a nobody to the top of Wall Street, as one of its most persuasive salesmen.



Corporate blues lend authority. Warm skin and luminous whites sell pleasure.
As Jordan loses control, the colours of luxury become evidence of its cost.
The same palette can tell a very different story.

See it in colour.

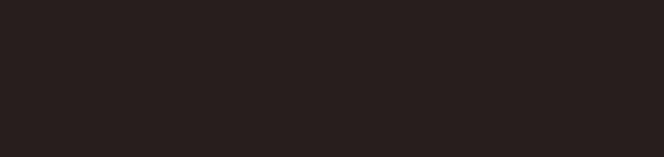
Explore the scenes that tell Jordan's story.



01 / ASPIRATION

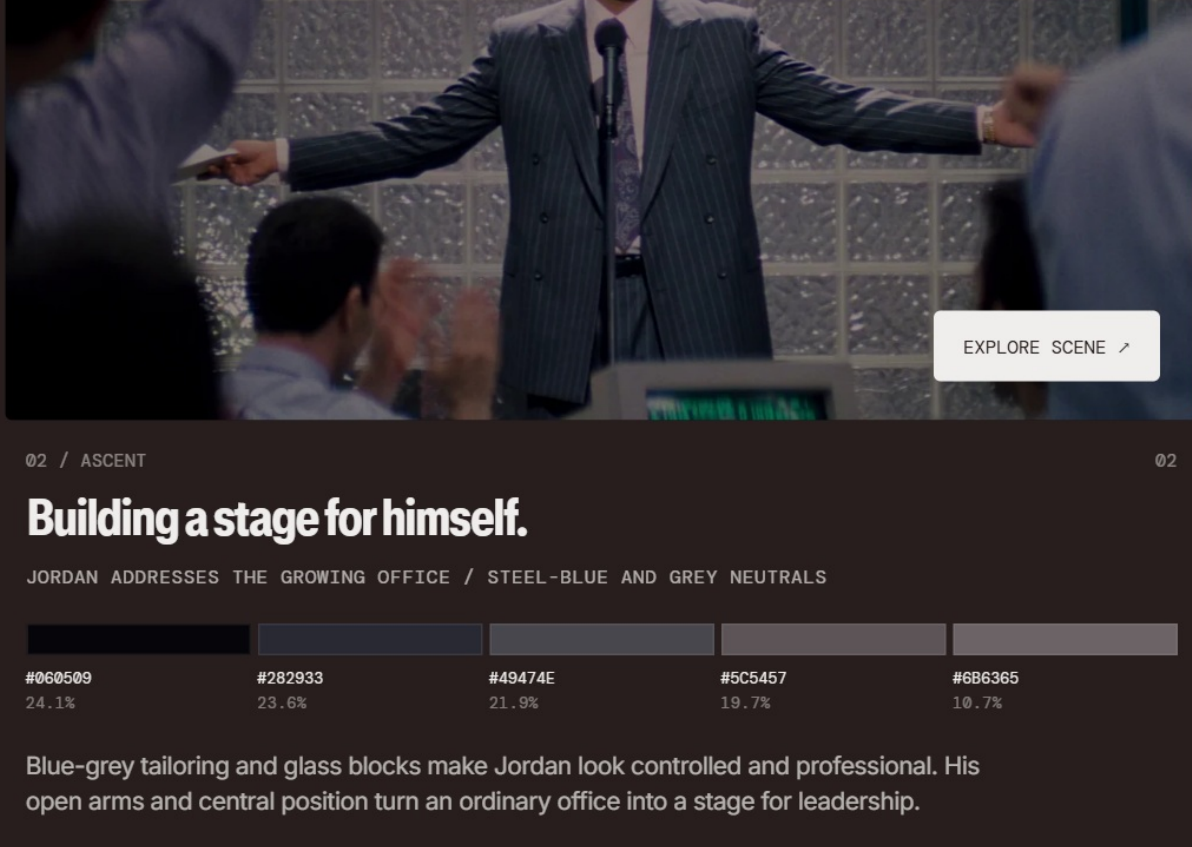
Learning the language of power.

LUNCH WITH MARK HANNA / COOL-WARM CONTRAST



Blue-grey skyline and tailored suits frame Wall Street as a world of composure. Warm skin and the restaurant setting make Hanna's cynical lesson feel sociable: exploitation arrives as friendly career advice.

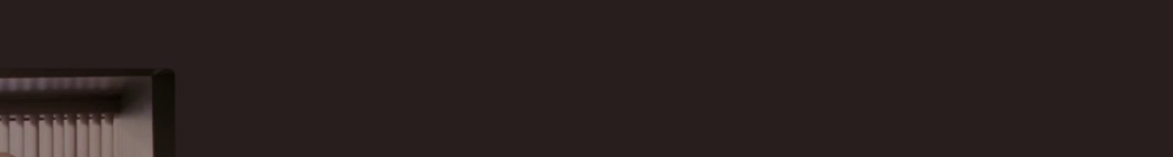
MOOD SEDUCTION · BELONGING



02 / ASCENT

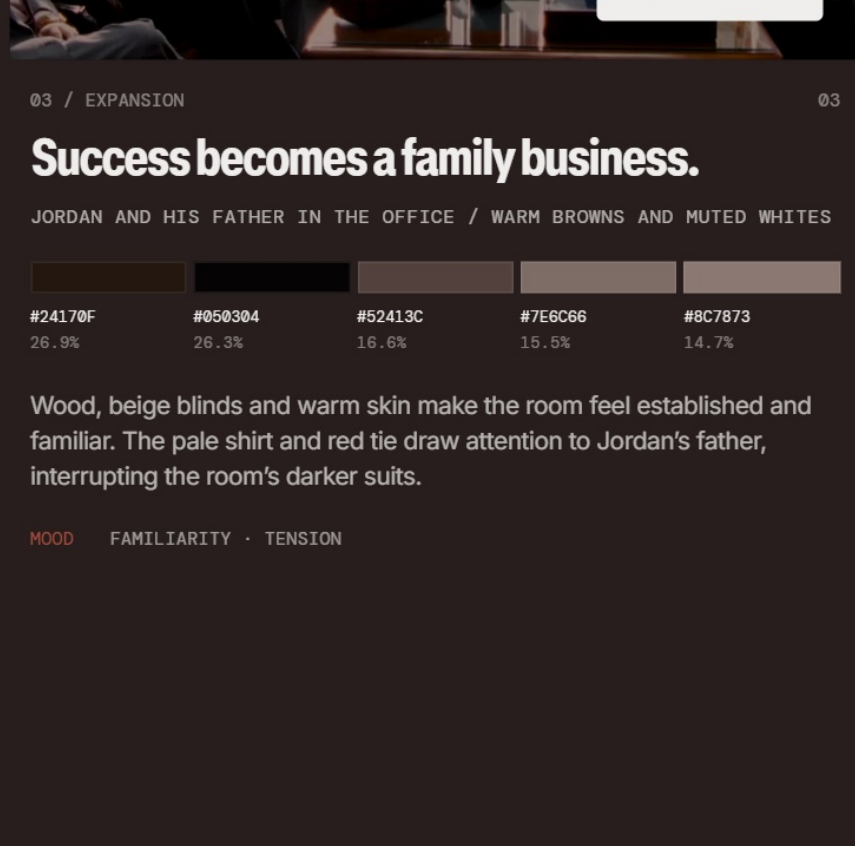
Building a stage for himself.

JORDAN ADDRESSES THE GROWING OFFICE / STEEL-BLUE AND GREY NEUTRALS



Blue-grey tailoring and glass blocks make Jordan look controlled and professional. His open arms and central position turn an ordinary office into a stage for leadership.

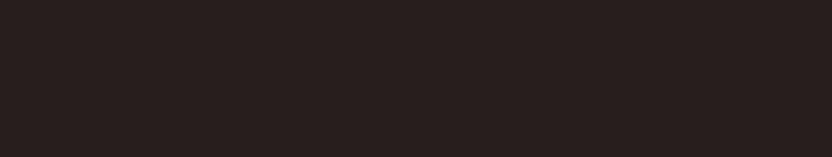
MOOD AUTHORITY · AMBITION



03 / EXPANSION

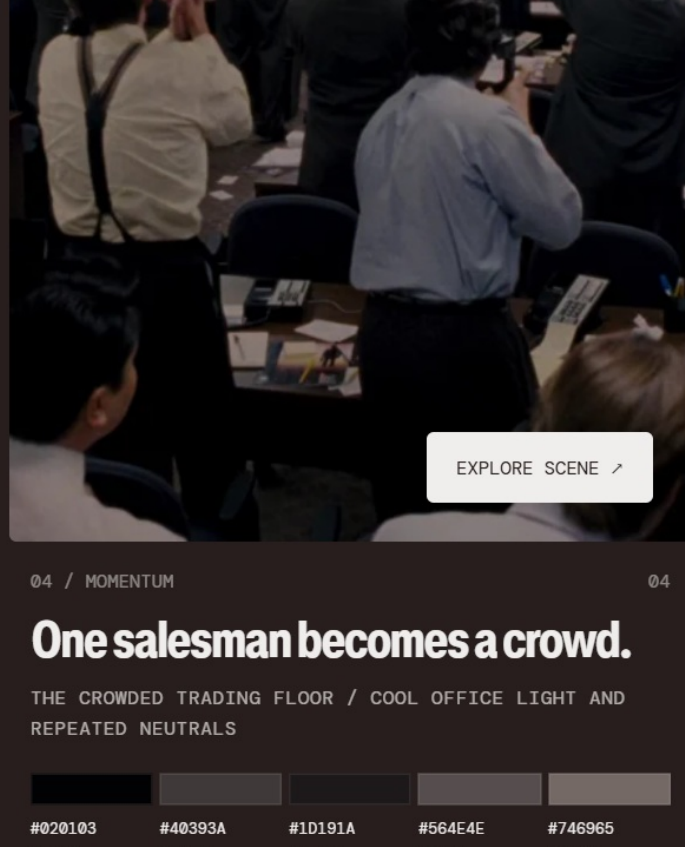
Success becomes a family business.

JORDAN AND HIS FATHER IN THE OFFICE / WARM BROWNS AND MUTED WHITES



Wood, beige blinds and warm skin make the room feel established and familiar. The pale shirt and red tie draw attention to Jordan's father, interrupting the room's darker suits.

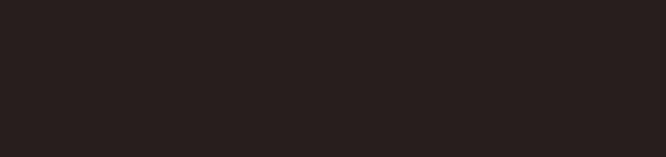
MOOD FAMILIARITY · TENSION



04 / MOMENTUM

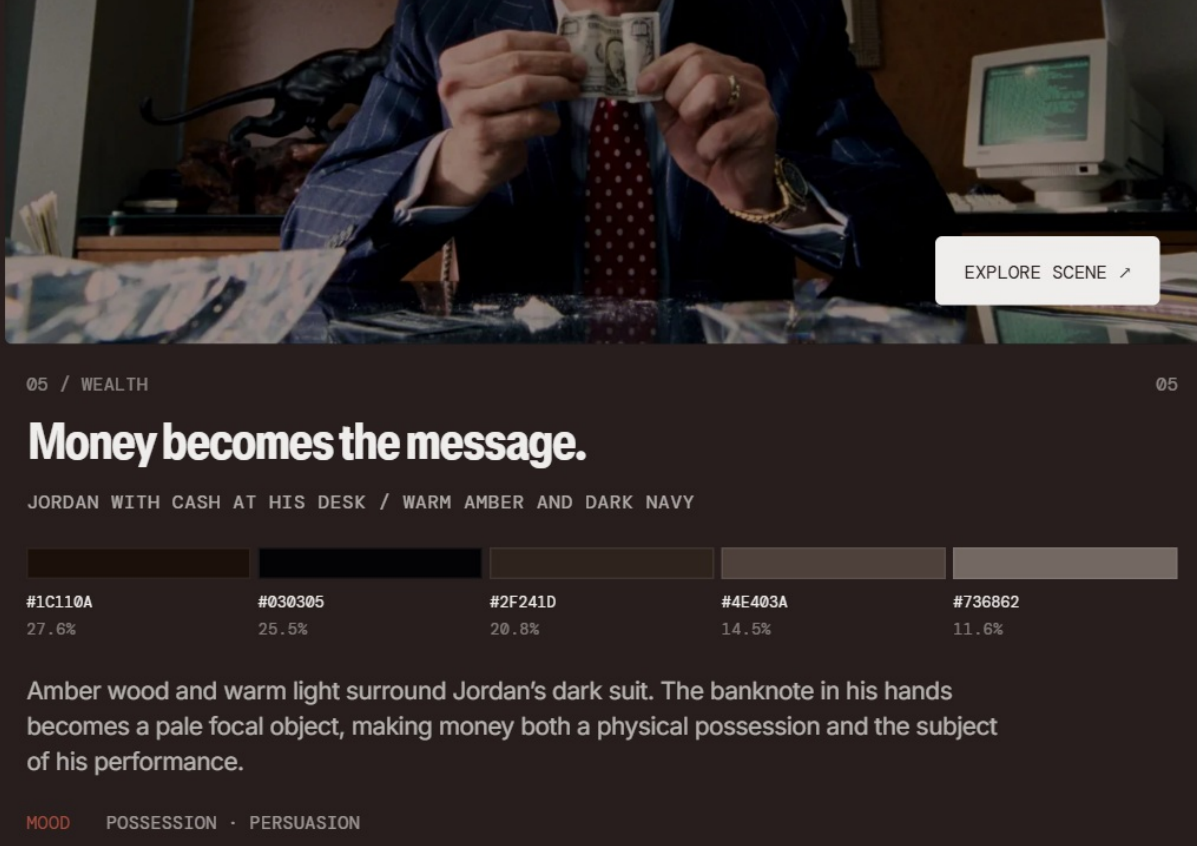
One salesman becomes a crowd.

THE CROWDED TRADING FLOOR / COOL OFFICE LIGHT AND REPEATED NEUTRALS



Pale shirts and dark jackets repeat across a dense room. Cool overhead light unifies the crowd, turning individual sellers into a visual pattern around Jordan's enterprise.

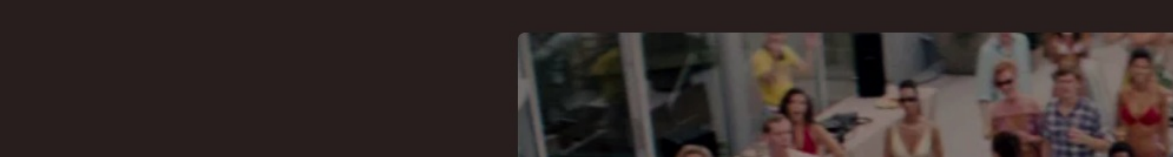
MOOD MOMENTUM · COLLECTIVE EXCITEMENT



05 / WEALTH

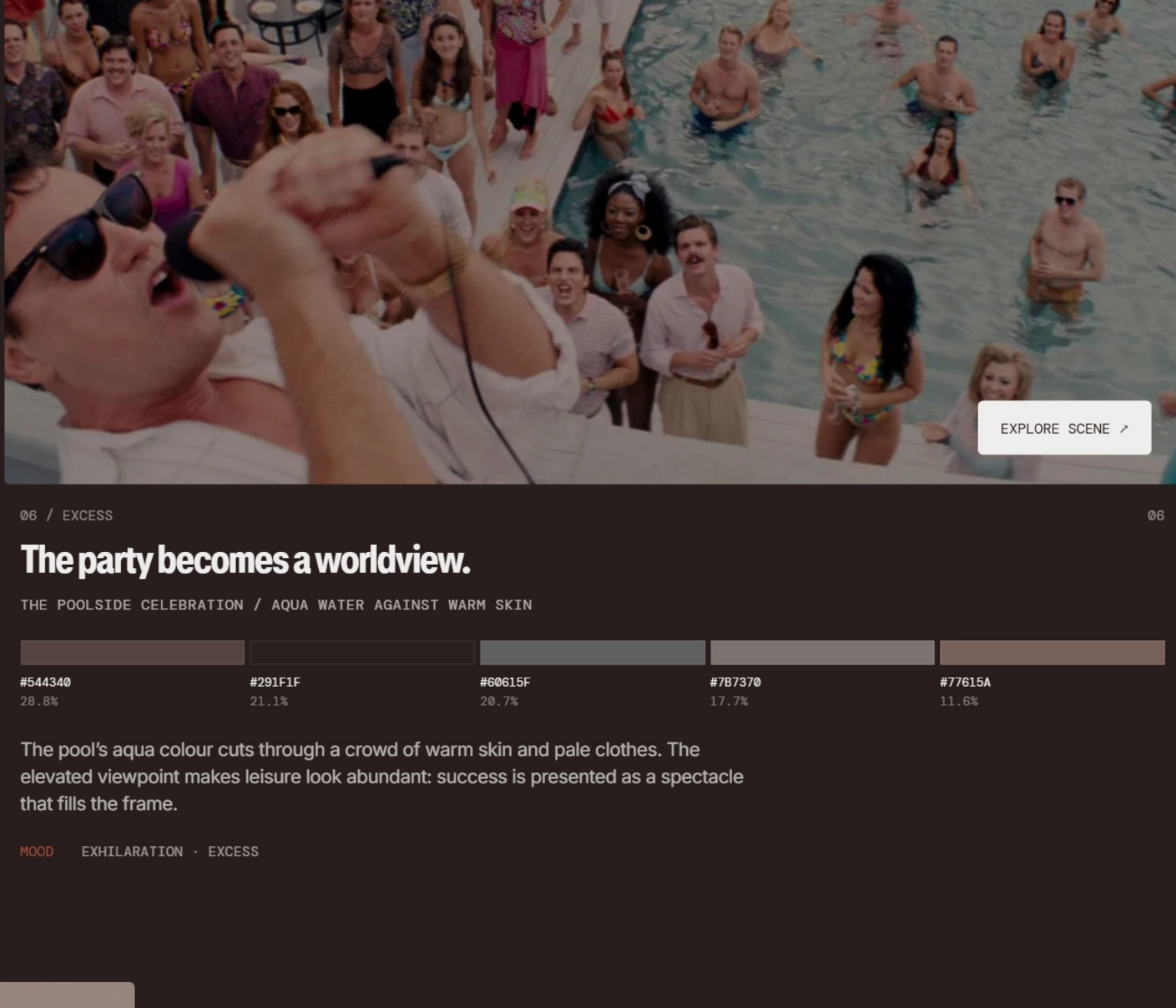
Money becomes the message.

JORDAN WITH CASH AT HIS DESK / WARM AMBER AND DARK NAVY



Amber wood and warm light surround Jordan's dark suit. The banknote in his hands becomes a pale focal object, making money both a physical possession and the subject of his performance.

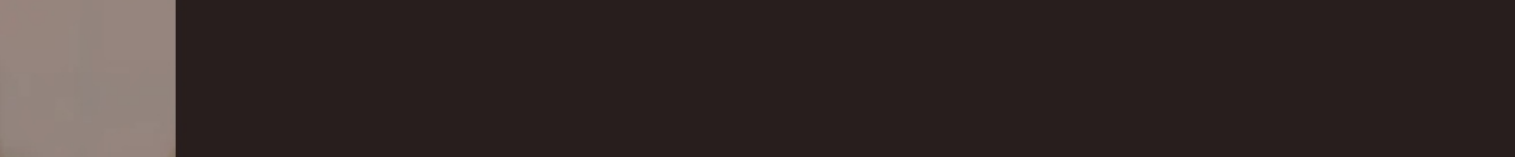
MOOD POSSESSION · PERSUASION



06 / EXCESS

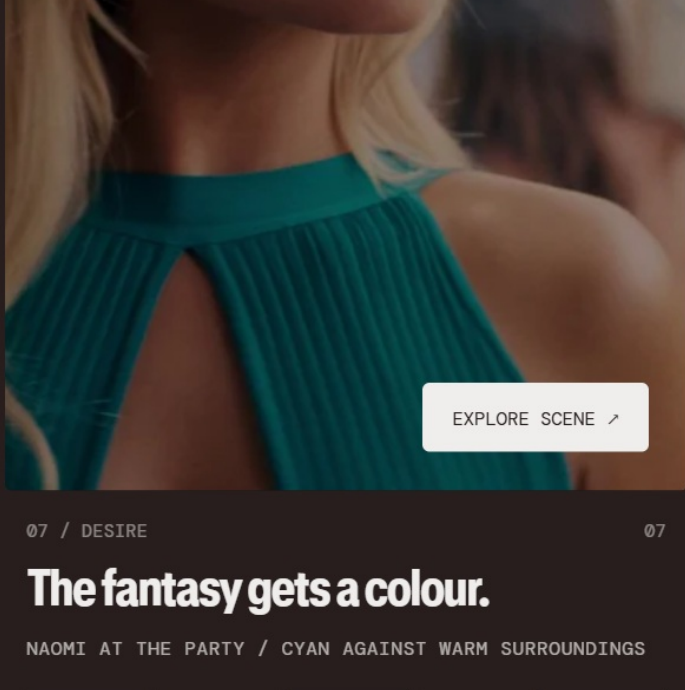
The party becomes a worldview.

THE POOLSIDE CELEBRATION / AQUA WATER AGAINST WARM SKIN



The pool's aqua colour cuts through a crowd of warm skin and pale clothes. The elevated viewpoint makes leisure look abundant: success is presented as a spectacle that fills the frame.

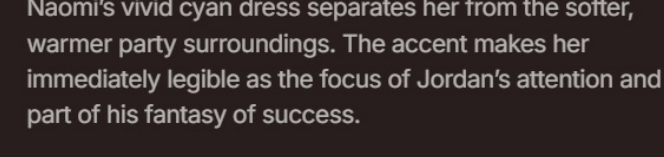
MOOD EXHILARATION · EXCESS



07 / DESIRE

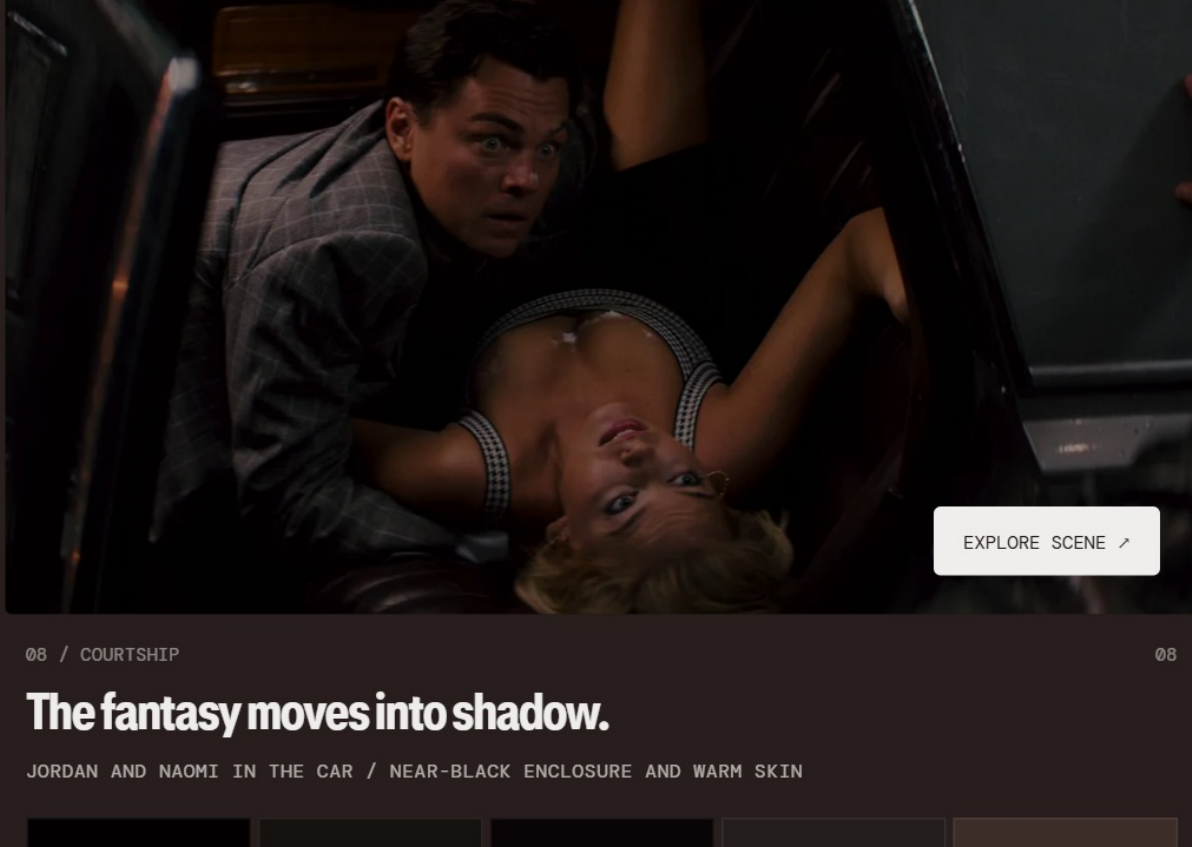
The fantasy gets a colour.

NAOMI AT THE PARTY / CYAN AGAINST WARM SURROUNDINGS



Naomi's vivid cyan dress separates her from the softer, warmer party surroundings. The accent makes her immediately legible as the focus of Jordan's attention and part of his fantasy of success.

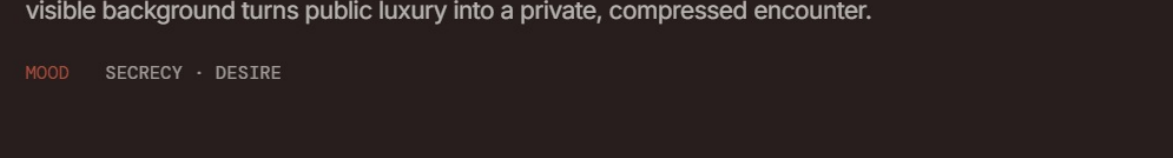
MOOD ATTRACTION · ASPIRATION



08 / COURTSHIP

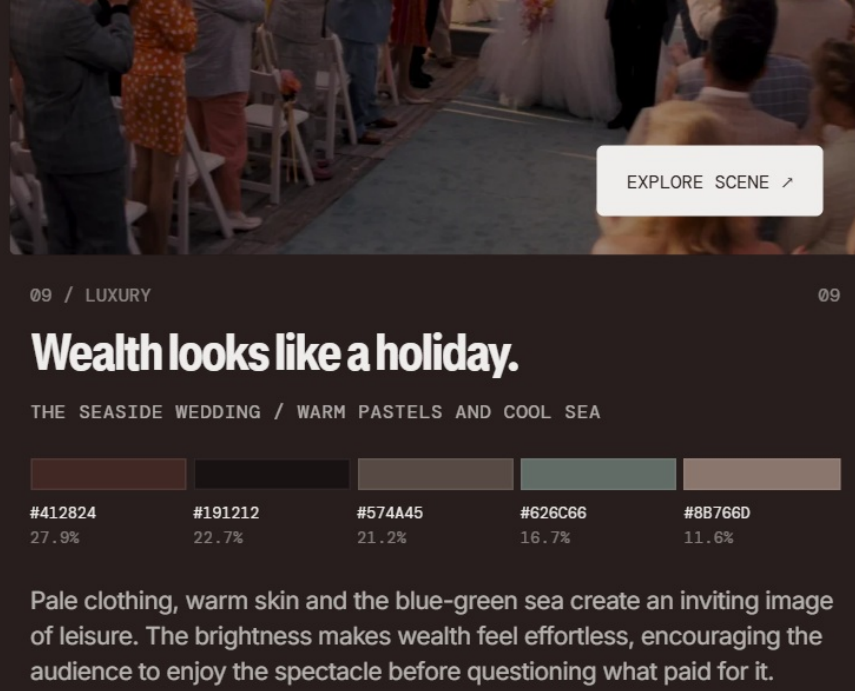
The fantasy moves into shadow.

JORDAN AND NAOMI IN THE CAR / NEAR-BLACK ENCLOSURE AND WARM SKIN



The car's dark interior encloses warmer faces and skin. The dramatic reduction in visible background turns public luxury into a private, compressed encounter.

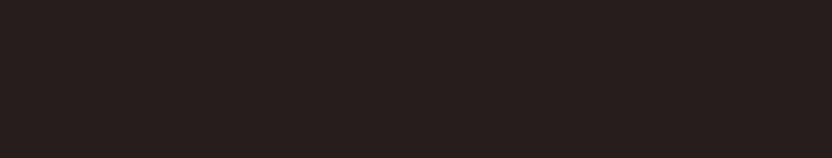
MOOD SECRECY · DESIRE



09 / LUXURY

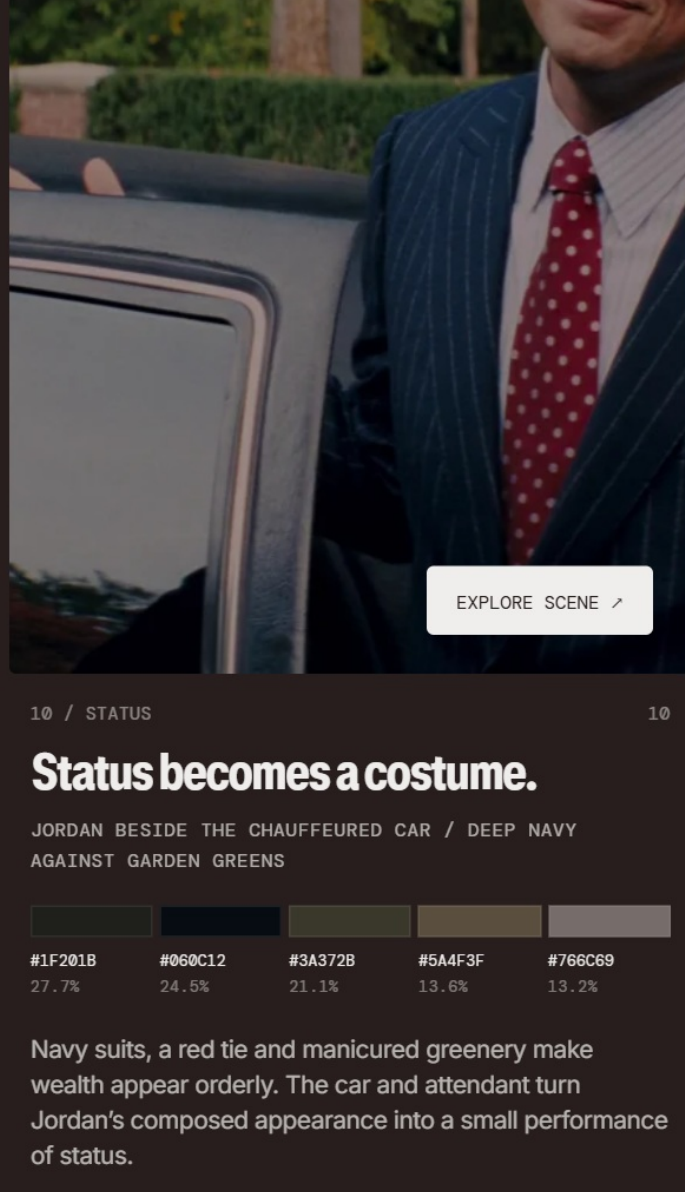
Wealth looks like a holiday.

THE SEASIDE WEDDING / WARM PASTELS AND COOL SEA



Pale clothing, warm skin and the blue-green sea create an inviting image of leisure. The brightness makes wealth feel effortless, encouraging the audience to enjoy the spectacle before questioning what paid for it.

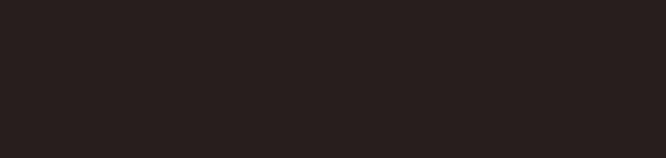
MOOD PLEASURE · WISH FULFILMENT



10 / STATUS

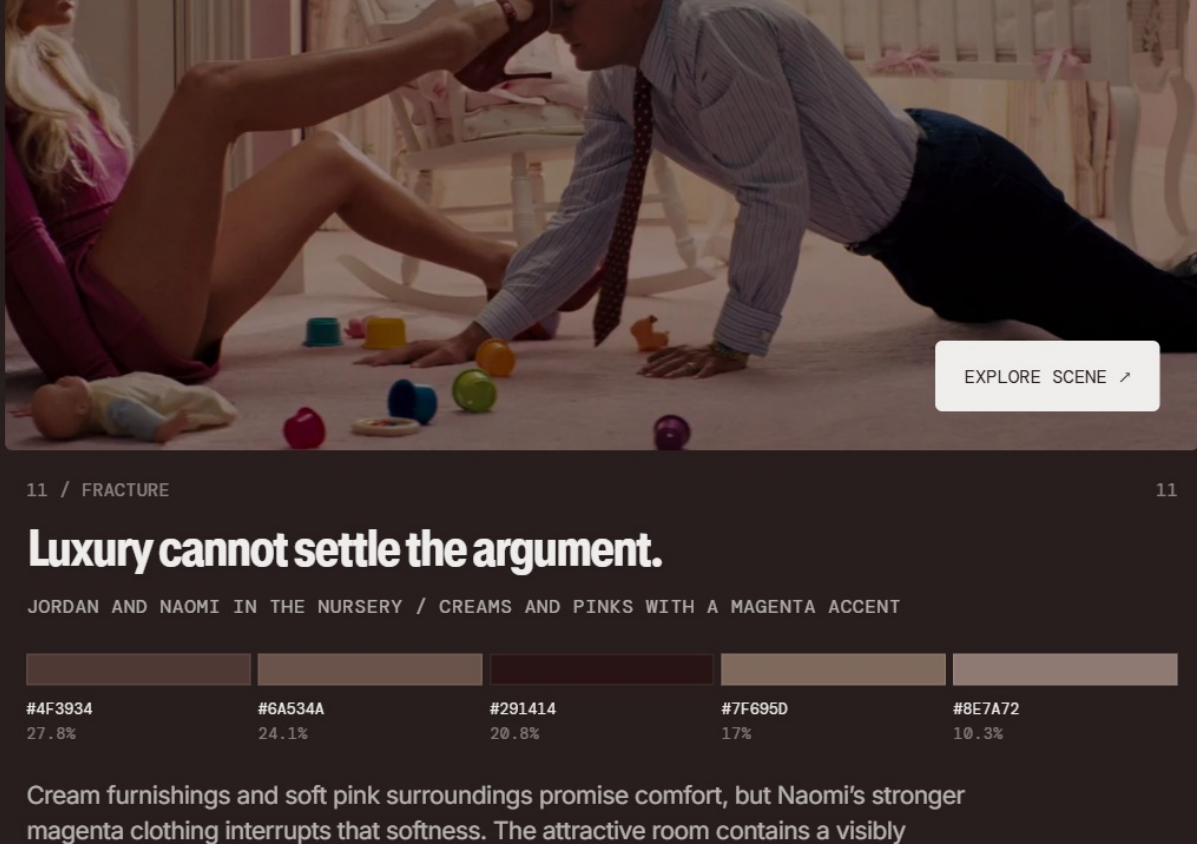
Status becomes a costume.

JORDAN BESIDE THE CHAUFFEURED CAR / DEEP NAVY AGAINST GARDEN GREENS



Navy suits, a red tie and manicured greenery make wealth appear orderly. The car and attendant turn Jordan's composed appearance into a small performance of status.

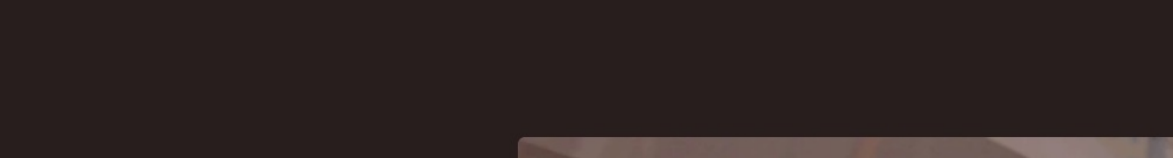
MOOD CONFIDENCE · SELF-DISPLAY



11 / FRACTURE

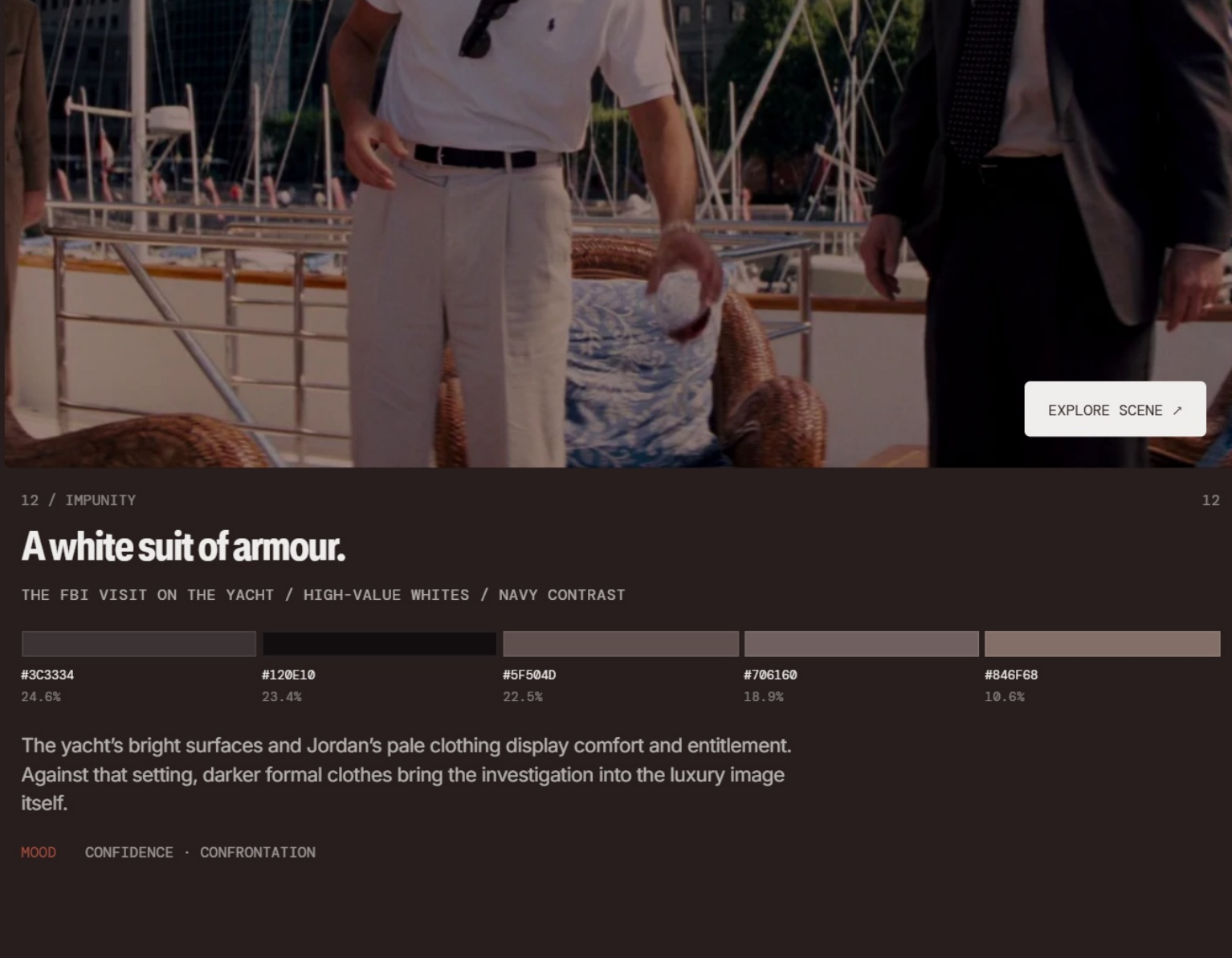
Luxury cannot settle the argument.

JORDAN AND NAOMI IN THE NURSERY / CREAMS AND PINKS WITH A MAGENTA ACCENT



Cream furnishings and soft pink surroundings promise comfort, but Naomi's stronger magenta clothing interrupts that softness. The attractive room contains a visibly unequal confrontation.

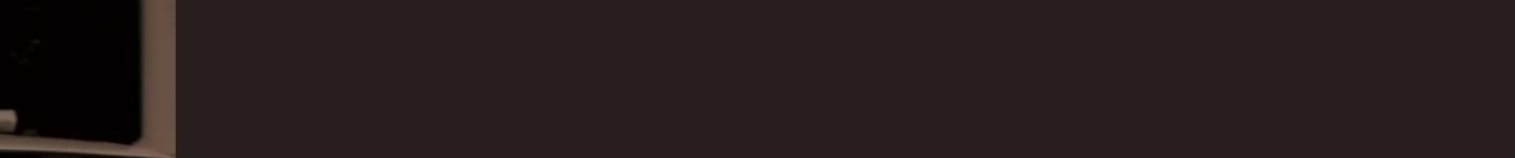
MOOD DOMESTIC TENSION · IMBALANCE



12 / IMPUNITY

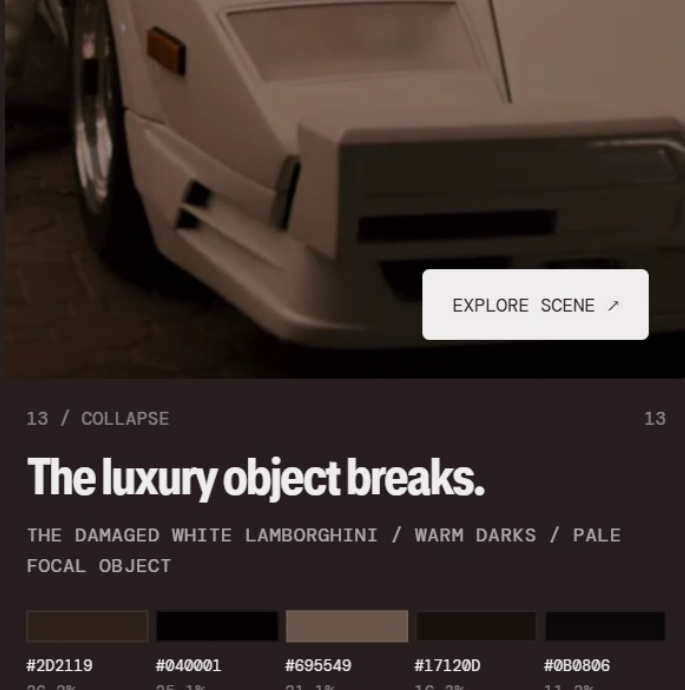
A white suit of armour.

THE FBI VISIT ON THE YACHT / HIGH-VALUE WHITES / NAVY CONTRAST



The yacht's bright surfaces and Jordan's pale clothing display comfort and entitlement. Against that setting, darker formal clothes bring the investigation into the luxury image itself.

MOOD CONFIDENCE · CONFRONTATION



13 / COLLAPSE

The luxury object breaks.

THE DAMAGED WHITE LAMBORGHINI / WARM DARKS / PALE FOCAL OBJECT



The white car remains conspicuous, but its damage changes the meaning of luxury. Warm, dark surroundings no longer promise comfort; they enclose the evidence of Jordan's lost control.

MOOD HUMILIATION · DISORIENTATION



14 / CONSEQUENCE

Private life meets a barrier.

JORDAN BEHIND THE TRANSPORT PARTITION / MUTED BLUE-GRAY AND BEIGE

Cool blue-grey surfaces and a plain beige shirt strip away the earlier display. The dark mesh behind Jordan replaces the open spaces and polished surfaces of his luxury world.

MOOD RESTRICTION · VULNERABILITY

A character in colour.

Five stages, one changing relationship to colour.

The film opens with excess, then rewinds; this map follows Jordan's life in story order.

01 / BEGINNING

The promise

Corporate blues and tired office greens give ambition a credible setting. Jordan learns to borrow the appearance of legitimacy.

02 / RISE

The performance

Repeated suits and pale shirts turn his personal sales pitch into an institution. Colour remains controlled even as the behaviour escalates.

03 / PEAK

The appetite

Cyan accents, warm skin and luminous whites sell pleasure, status and immunity. The attractive image is part of the seduction.

04 / FALL

The fracture

Luxury objects lose their promise; institutional backdrops replace spectacle. Familiar colours change meaning as control disappears.

05 / ENDING

The audience

Subdued ordinary spaces shift attention from the celebrity salesman to the society still willing to listen.

THE PERFORMANCE CONTINUES

Still selling. Still watching.



WATCH JORDAN BELFORT

The real Jordan Belfort demonstrates his sales approach. A companion video to the film study.

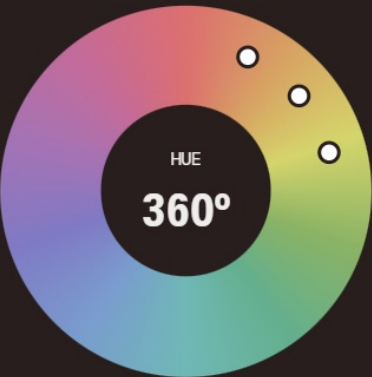
[Watch on YouTube ↗](#)

Look a little closer.

Colour terminology helps describe what is visible.
It does not turn an interpretation into a psychological experiment.

Relationships on the wheel

ANALOGOUS COMPLEMENTARY MONOCHROMATIC



Neighbouring hues
Illustrative hue relationship

Neighbouring hues can produce continuity. Browns and warm neutrals often occupy a narrow hue range, though many are too desaturated to read as strong colour.

Examine a measured frame

01 / Lunch with Mark Hanna		▼
Saturation	25	/ 100
Brightness proxy	30	/ 100
Tonal spread	53	/ 100

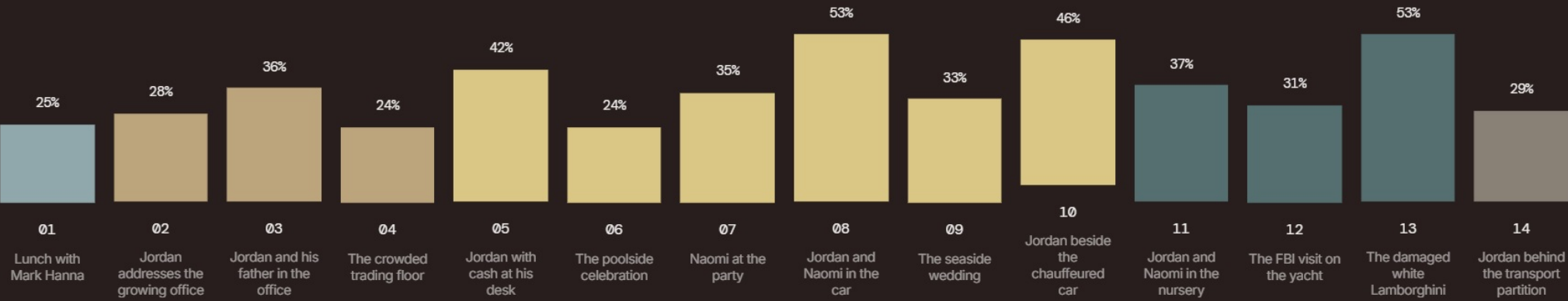
Hue identifies the colour family. **Saturation** describes its intensity. **Value** describes lightness or darkness in the image.

Colour temperature here means the perceived warm–cool relationship. No Kelvin values are inferred from a screenshot.

Colour harmony describes a relationship between hues. **Associative colour** gains meaning through repeated objects, settings and narrative context.

A selection, not a smooth decline.

Mean HSV saturation across the selected frames. Changes reflect composition, setting and screenshot encoding as well as filmmaking choices.



How the measurements were made

Each selected image is proportionally resized to a maximum of 1600 × 1000 pixels for display, then to 240 × 160 for sampling. Rows averaging below 5/255 are excluded to reduce black-bar influence. A deterministic median-cut quantisation produces five RGB clusters, ranked by pixel share. HEX values describe the cluster colours.

Saturation is the mean HSV S across sampled pixels. The brightness proxy is the mean of 0.2126R + 0.7152G + 0.0722B on normalised, gamma-encoded RGB. Tonal spread is that signal's 95th minus 5th percentile. These two measures are descriptive code-value proxies, not calibrated luminance or photographic exposure.

The sampling is purposive, not representative of every shot. Screenshots may differ from a calibrated cinema master; resizing, compression and tone mapping may affect the result. Percentages describe this frame sample, not screen time. Emotional readings are contextual interpretations, with no audience experiment or universal colour–emotion claim.

A beautiful image. A rotten promise.

The most revealing colour shift is not always a change of hue. It is a change of meaning. White can sell innocence or expose wreckage. Blue can signal professional authority or institutional control.

Through Jordan's rise and fall, the attractive image invites us to want what he wants. The final audience asks whether that appetite has disappeared—or simply found its next salesman.

01 Colour sells the fantasy.

02 Context changes the meaning.

03 The audience completes the cycle.

Primary film

The Wolf of Wall Street (2013), directed by Martin Scorsese; cinematography by Rodrigo Prieto. Film stills supplied for this class analysis. Rights remain with their respective owners.

Course framework

Week 5: "The Psychology of Colour in Film." Concepts: colour schemes, associative colour, mood and emotional response. The supplied peer PDFs informed the level of analysis, not this website's design.

Further context

[Paramount / Film information ↗](#)

[American Cinematographer / Boom and Bust ↗](#)

[Design & motion reference / Tom Carder Media ↗](#)

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